How to – in the Causal Map app

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How to – in the Causal Map app. Introduction

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In this chapter we look at some examples of specific workflows in causal mapping, mostly illustrated with the Causal Map app. It's work in progress, we only have a couple of pages at this point.

If you want to know about how to answer specific questions with causal mapping, look here:

Individual questions -- introduction

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Print view of links

Bundle: Diet improved; Diversified >> Improved health

Source: MNY-5

The meals I buy in the market have changed because I have the option to buy various goods. The spare food type has change as I now have access to better seeds for my farm and some material.

Increased

The motive for this change is in the varieties of foods cultivated in my farm, in my livestock creation and also in the food varieties from the market.

More variety

The reason is as a result of the varieties and the different foods. We have a variety of good in the market. Some from my garden and it is the reason I am healthy.

Source: MSX-1

Increased

MORE FOOD VARIETIES THAT GENERATED A GOOD NUTRITION IN THE FAMILY overall AND WE ALSO CONSERVE MORE FOOD. Increased from the introduction production of horticulture such as tomatoes, onions these enabled more food. With tomatoes and onions we could now do stew to avoid only eating green vegetables.

More variety

AFTER, THE GOOD WAYS OF CONSERVATION OF FOOD AND VARIETIES IN FOODS HELPED A GOOD RESULT IN THE HEALTH OF THE FAMILY.

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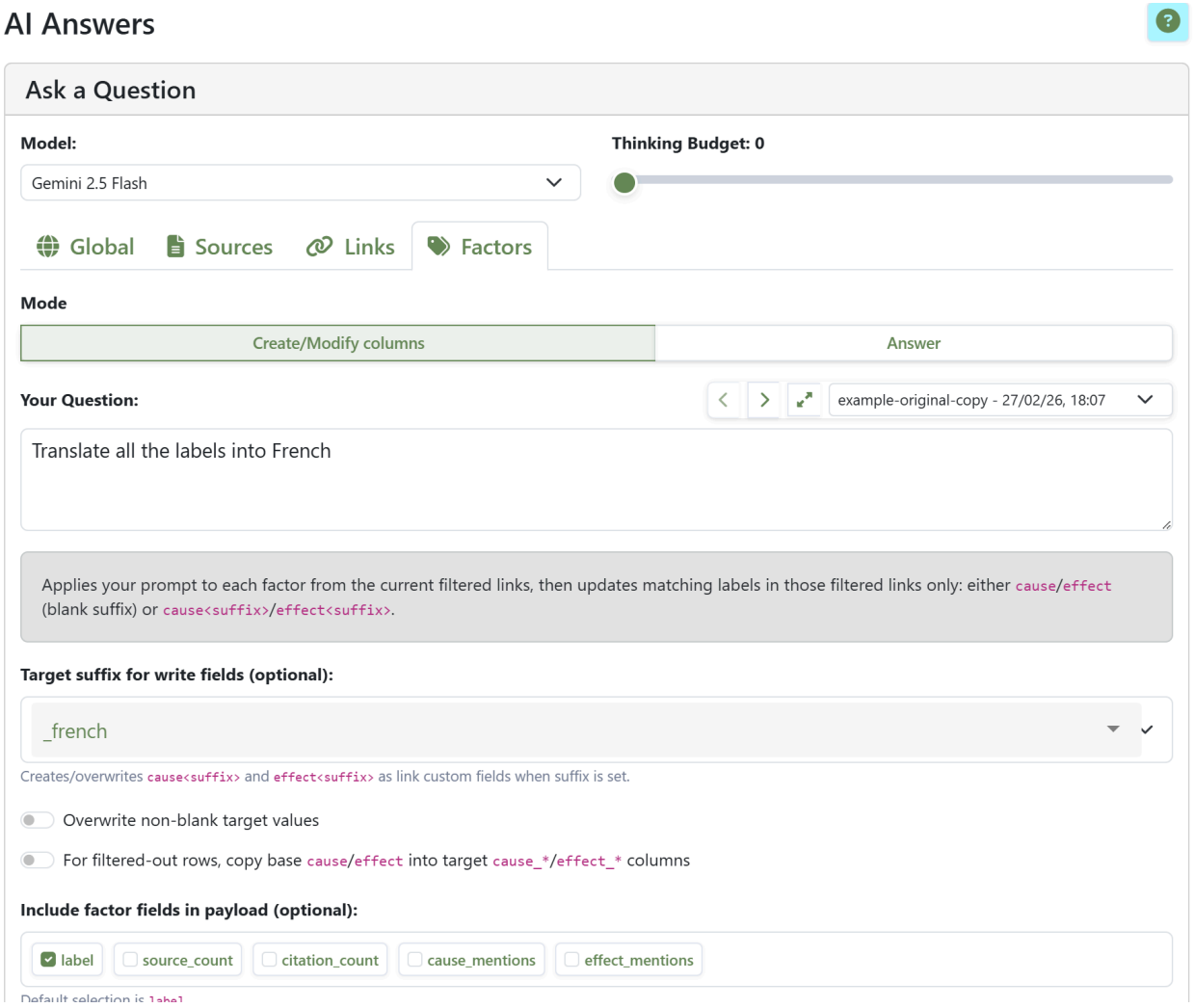
Translate factor labels

This is easy if you use AI Answers: Factor recoding. Just create a version of your links like cause_french and effect_french



.... so that you can easily switch from one language to another with a Temporary Links filter:

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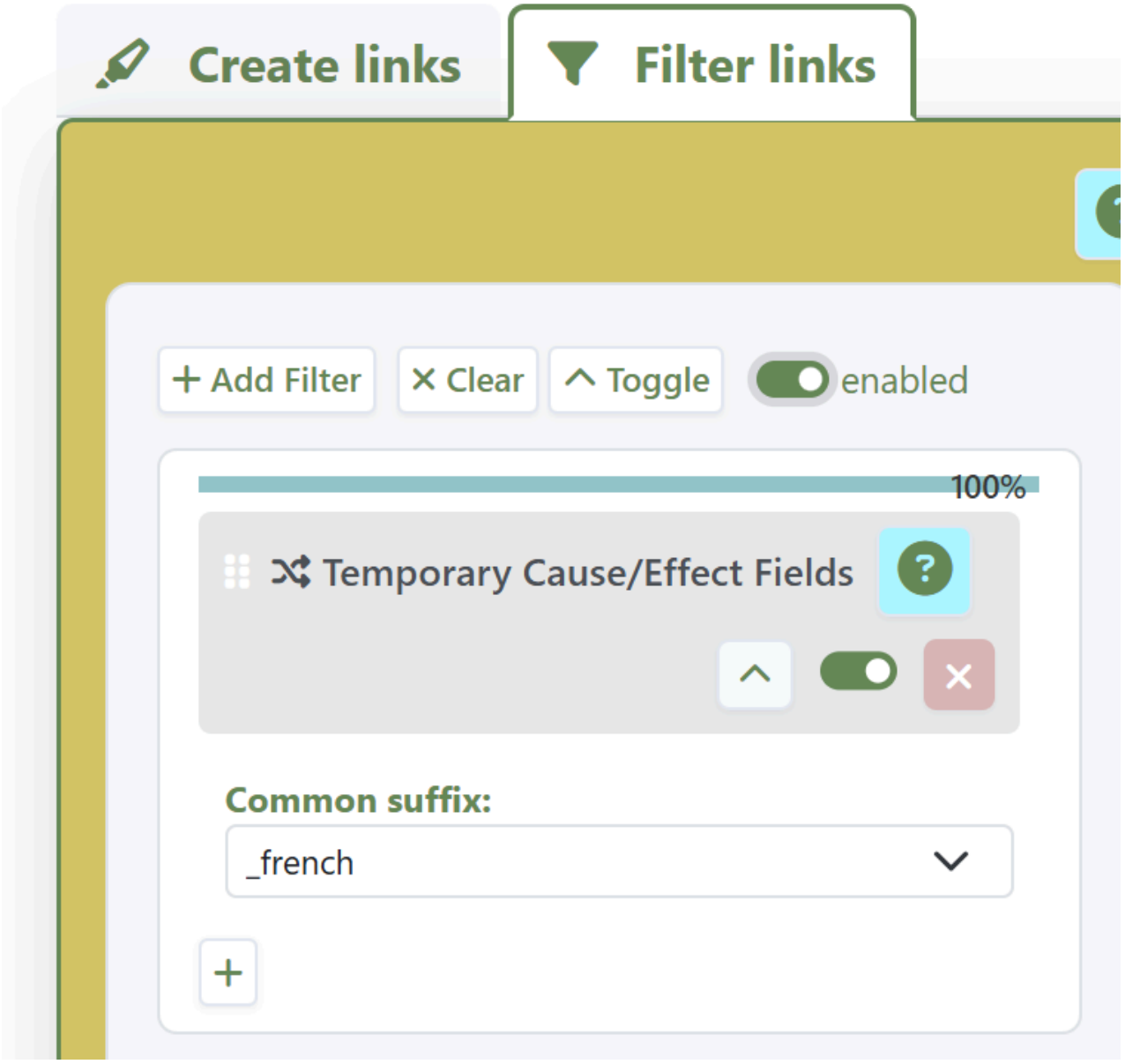

... Which then results in a map something like this.

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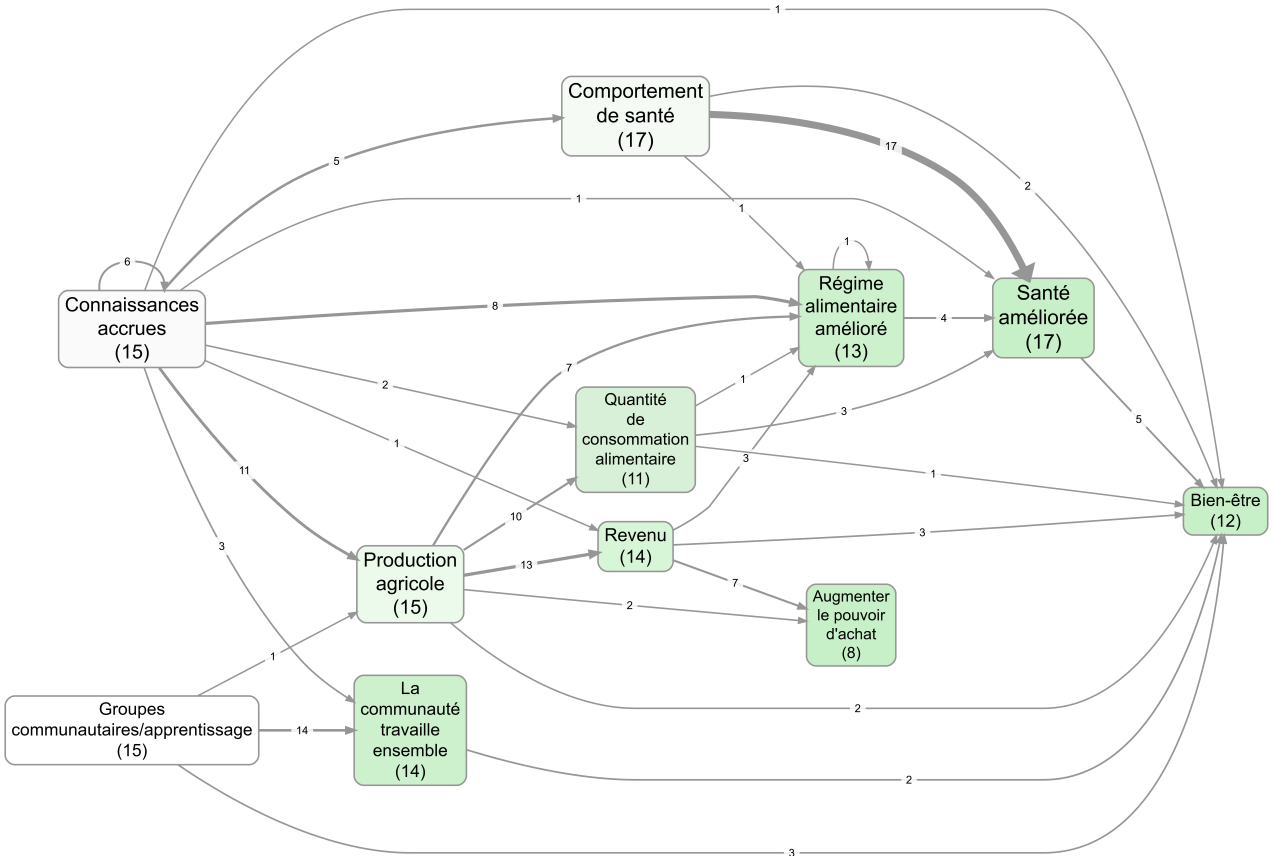

AI Answers can be really useful!

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Vignettes

1) What are vignettes and why use them?

Some people love just staring at a map and clicking the links to view the quotes behind them. Other people are like "No, what does it say, tell me in actual words already!"

Vignettes turn your coded causal map into readable prose. The Causal Map AI can draft a narrative that names themes, tensions, and patterns in your material -- or whatever else you want. You stay in control: you write the prompt (tone, audience, structure), and you can edit the text afterwards. You can choose which AI model to use. It's a good idea to include a "Checking" phase, where another AI instance checks the work of the first one. As usual, your Account Settings determine where the model is run, e.g. in the EU.

2) Whole-map Vignettes

Use this when you want a bird's-eye story of everything that is currently in the map (respecting your current filters and source selection). The app sends a compact summary of factors and bundled links (with sentiment), evidence snippets (quotes and source IDs from highlighted bundles where available), and up to 30 "typical" sources scored by how much they represent common bundles, each with bundles, link-level quotes, and a small metadata preview (title, filename, and simple custom fields). If you want the narrative to emphasise particular edges, set Map Formatting → Links highlight to Significant or Feedback loop first; that snapshot is included so the model can focus there.

Typical-source

Use this when you want a single-respondent case study: the app picks the most "typical" source for the current map view (using link counts and coverage of bundles, with a correction to make sure very long documents do not always win). It sends that source's full text plus its links with quotes and sentiment, so the model can write as if telling one story. Do not ask it to generalise across the whole project in this mode: the prompt and data are scoped to that one source.

Example: Vignette for "Lonely in London"

See [Causal mapping of loneliness interviews]

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The Gravity of Isolation

The data reveals a profound and interlocking narrative about modern isolation, where the ultimate destination for many pathways is the crushing sensation of **Feeling Like a Nobody**. This central experience acts as a gravitational pull, drawing in various social and internal struggles. It was observed by 38 sources that this profound emptiness becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy, feeding back into itself in a devastating loop that traps individuals in a state of profound disconnection.

> "with the experience of loneliness, the first thing that came to my head was darkness, and I just felt like, people feel lonely, usually find like a dark place" — PANT32
> "It makes me feel upset because I feel like I haven't changed like everyone around me is changing, moving away to better themselves and I feel like I'm still stuck in the same place that I haven't changed, and then maybe it's me that's like the problem" — PANT35

The Social Fracture

A major catalyst for this darkness is the **Breakdown of Friendships**. 41 sources noted that the fracturing of social bonds directly led to feeling like a nobody. This breakdown often spirals; 24 sources observed that losing friends triggers further social withdrawal, creating a feedback loop where the breakdown of friendships simply leads to more broken ties.

> "I think that, the feeling of the void that someone leaving leaves can make you feel lonelier than you probably are" — VIEW1M
> "And that's where you start to question yourself about oh I cannot be bothered to go to gym or I cannot to go work. Because you're lonely because the fact that you broke up with someone, um, yeah." — VIEW43

Compounding this social fracture is a **Total Lack of Support**, which 23 sources linked to feeling entirely invisible and alienated. When individuals feel they have no one to lean on, it breeds a deep sense of inadequacy and isolation.

> "the specific kind of loneliness that comes from being connected to people because of common factors, but feeling lonely because of there not being certain deeper things that you think are important. So... do you, are you in... are you just around each other, but not in actual support of each other? Or you might not truly believe in each other." — VIEW18

The Pressure to Fit In

The modern pressure cooker of the **Social Media Popularity Contest** was highlighted by 18

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sources as a direct pathway to feeling like a nobody. The constant, curated comparison leaves individuals feeling inadequate and left behind.

> "nowadays people just do things because it's like, I need to look like I'm doing something on, on Instagram, otherwise I'm just a nobody, that's another form of loneliness, do you know what I mean?" — VIEW11

Similarly, the exhausting act of **Conforming to the Crowd** was cited by 24 sources as a driver of profound emptiness. Trying to fit into molds that don't match one's true self leads to a **Disassociation from Identity** (noted by 16 sources). Conversely, **Being Singled Out** for being different was reported by 35 sources to plunge individuals into feeling like a nobody, creating a painful paradox where both fitting in and standing out lead to the same dark place.

> "you pick out the worst in yourself but the best in everyone else and it makes you feel like you don't want to be around anyone else- because you haven't got the same quali-qualities as them." — VIEW37
> "others not understanding you, you, just being misunderstood, you know, leads to loneliness." — VIEW11

The Internal Prison

These external pressures inevitably seep inward, creating a landscape of **Internal Mental Blocking**. 21 sources described how this mental paralysis leads straight to feeling like a nobody, while 17 sources noted that this mental blocking feeds into itself, trapping the individual in their own head with their self-doubt.

> "if I ignore it and I focus on the feeling of loneliness and emptiness, and existence, that's when I could stay in the state of loneliness, when I ignore my longing for more" — VIEW3M
> "my way of thinking is not like, it's like I'm basically like kind of restricted myself from like, for reaching a high level" — VIEW11

This internal trap frequently transitions into **Built-up Frustration** (mentioned by 13 sources as stemming from mental blocks) and **Crippling Mental Anxiety**. 13 sources observed that feeling like a nobody generates severe anxiety, which in turn—according to 15 sources—reinforces the feeling of being a nobody, creating a suffocating cycle of panic and isolation.

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> "And if you have more worries and that makes you feel... It makes you feel like you, you can't be heard, because it's like, even if you're screaming or shouting, it's like being in space" — VIEW11
> "if you fail and then like obviously you have a whole class of 50 people watching you crumble and burn and then just after that you just feel like you shouldn't even be there, you know, you'll, you're not worthy of being at that place anymore" — YPART1

The Search for Connection

In an attempt to escape the void, many turn to **Keeping Busy**. 20 sources described how staying occupied becomes a self-sustaining loop. However, the effectiveness of this strategy is highly mixed. While 19 sources found that keeping busy successfully led to **Finding Matching Human Energy**, 26 sources reported that merely filling time ultimately still resulted in feeling like a nobody, as the underlying void remained unaddressed.

> "I feel lonely if I stay in my house for too long ... if I stay at home then, and if I don't have anything to do, then I'll watch films and I'll feel like I'm really bored" — VIEW34
> "making stuff makes me feel like this is my role in this world" — VIEW11

Genuine **Face-to-face Interaction** was highlighted by 22 sources as a vital pathway to finding that matching human energy. Yet, even the pursuit of connection is fraught; 17 sources warned that finding matching human energy can sometimes paradoxically lead to a breakdown of friendships if old bonds are neglected, or if the energy turns out to be mismatched, plunging them back into the cycle of isolation.

> "when I read those quotes, you feel... not happy, what makes you happy. Like think positive, so think positive, and stay around positive people to make you feel better." — VIEW34
> "they kind of understand what I'm trying to do, so it's like, it's easier to be around people like that, yeah." — VIEW11

Model: gemini-3.1-pro-preview

Bookmark

#1410 — https://app.causalmap.app/?bookmark=1410

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Different kinds of coding and recoding

	Hard coding	Hard recoding	Links recoding	Factors recoding	Soft recoding
Accuracy	Highest	...	...	...	Lowest
Speed	Slowest	...	...	...	Fastest
Manual	Just code manually	Make a copy of your file, delete links and start again	Edit manually in Links table or Map, - or use search/replace in Links table	Edit manually in Factors table or Map, - or use search/replace in Factors table - or Bulk Edit	-
AI	Just code with AI, with/without a codebook	As above, or just put the switch "skip coded sources" to off	AI Answers / Links. Recode labels permanently or into temporary cause/effect columns.	AI Answers / Filters. Recode labels permanently or into temporary cause/effect columns	Apply magnetic labels in Soft Recode filter

What's the point of Links and Factors recoding? What's the difference?

- Soft recoding is only as good as the underlying embedding space, and it is never perfect.
- Hard recoding can take a long time, is expensive, and does not encourage experimentation
- With Links/Factors recoding, you can:
  - Recode just the currently filtered sources/links (or all links)
  - Recode the permanent cause/effect labels or recode into one or more sets of temporary columns, e.g. `experiment1_cause` and `experiment1_effect`, and then use these temporary labels in your maps and tables.
  - There is also another option Answers which is not about recoding; it is simply a way to send your links and/or factors data to an AI and getting a text answer.

But the main point is that rather than just hoping the magnetisation will work the way you want it to, you can do smart recoding as if you had an assistant to work through each label. For example you can say "Relabel everything which expresses a decrease or lack of something with a ~" or "Look at all these labels and tag each with `[Food]` or `[Health]"

.

- You can even bring other columns into play, for example citation count, source count etc.
- Links recoding is significantly more powerful because you can also include the actual Quote as well as both Cause and Effect. This means the AI can make its decision with a lot more

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context. So this is almost like recoding from scratch, but the original coding has already identified causal claims and all we have to do is relabel the labels with the same complete information about the claim.

- Be careful: it's tempting to say things like "Find 3-8 top-level factor labels which cover the meaning of all these labels and recode them with the new top-level labels", but remember the "Rows per call" slider: with a large set of links and lots of quotes you will probably have to break up your work into multiple chunks, and each call may come up with different labels. In this case you could use the Answers mode (or the Cluster part of Soft Recode filter) first to develop some labels.

Recoding labels temporarily ▸

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Adding and using custom columns for your links

Custom link columns let you store extra information on each causal claim, beyond the standard fields like **sentiment** and **tags**.

They are useful when you want to capture something more specific or more structured, for example:

- a confidence score
- a policy area
- a mechanism type
- whether the claim is based on lived experience, hearsay, or observation
- a time horizon such as short / medium / long term
- a project-specific code that only matters in this study

Why use custom columns?

Tags are quick and flexible, and sentiment is built-in for direction of effect. But sometimes that is not enough.

Use **tags** when:

- you want a quick label like `#uncertain` or `#important`
- a link may need several labels at once
- you mainly want fast searching and filtering

Use a **custom column** when:

- you want a named field with a clear purpose, such as `confidence`
- you want one value per link for that field
- you want to sort, group, break down, or visualise links using that field
- you want a coding scheme that other people can understand and reuse consistently

So the short version is:

- **tags** are loose and many-per-link
- **custom columns** are structured and field-based

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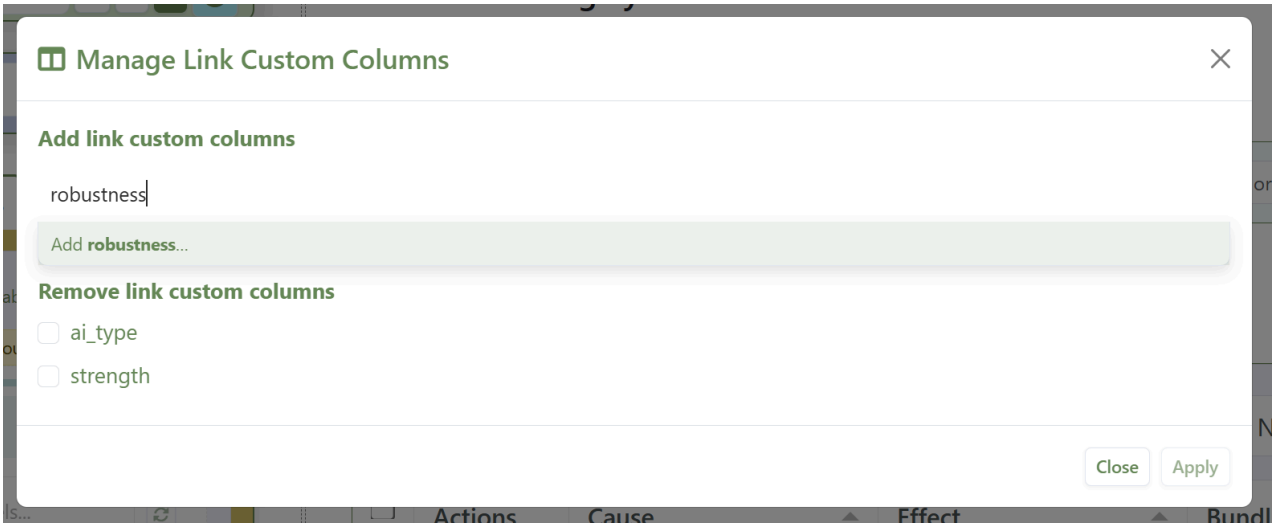
Two ways to create a link custom column

1. From Manage Link Custom Columns

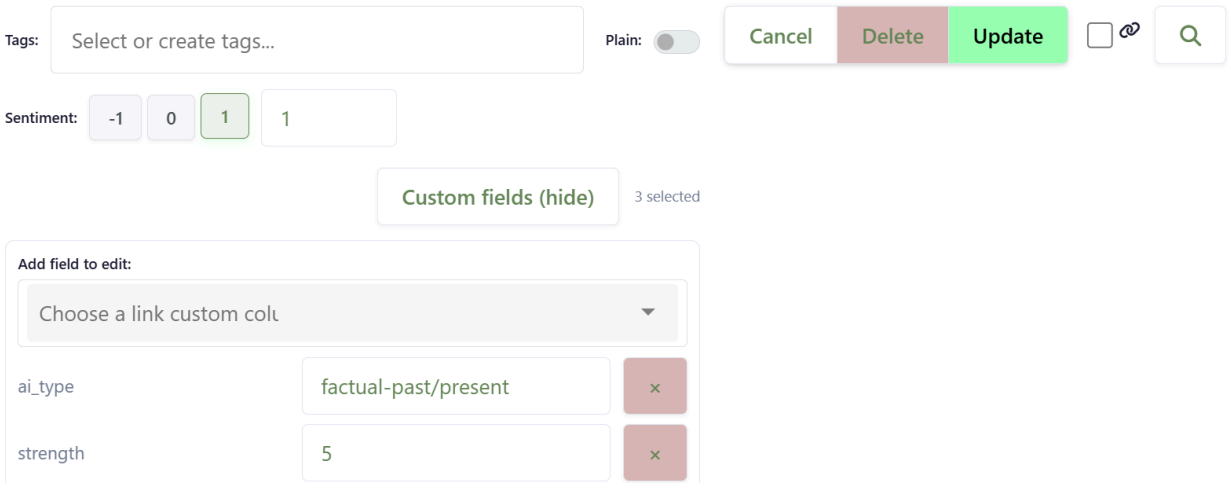


This is the best route when you already know the field name you want to add across the project. It works the same as for adding custom columns in the *sources* tab.

1. Open the **Links** tab.
2. Open **Manage Link Custom Columns**.
3. Type the new field name.
4. Apply the change.

That creates the field for the project, so it is available across your links.

2. Directly from the Link Editor



This is useful when you are coding and realise, in the moment, that you need a new field.

1. Open an existing link or create a new one.
2. Open the **Custom fields** panel in the Link Editor.

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3. In the field picker, type a new field name.
4. Confirm that you want to create it for the project.

The editor stays open, and you can carry on coding.

How to fill in values

Once a link custom column exists, you can edit its values in two main places:

- in the **Link Editor**, by opening the **Custom fields** panel and choosing the fields you want to see
- in the **Links Table**, by showing the custom columns and editing cells there

This is useful because some people prefer to code while reading evidence in the editor, while others prefer to review many coded links side by side in the table.

How to use custom columns in the Links Table

Once you have filled in some values, custom columns become useful immediately in the table.

For example, you can:

- sort links by that column
- filter to one value
- group rows by that column
- use breakdowns based on that column

This is often the easiest way to answer questions like:

- Which mechanisms appear most often?
- Which claims were coded as high confidence?
- How do links differ by policy area?

In other words, custom columns make your links table more like an analysis table, not just a coding log.

How to use custom columns in map visualisation

Custom columns can also drive map display.

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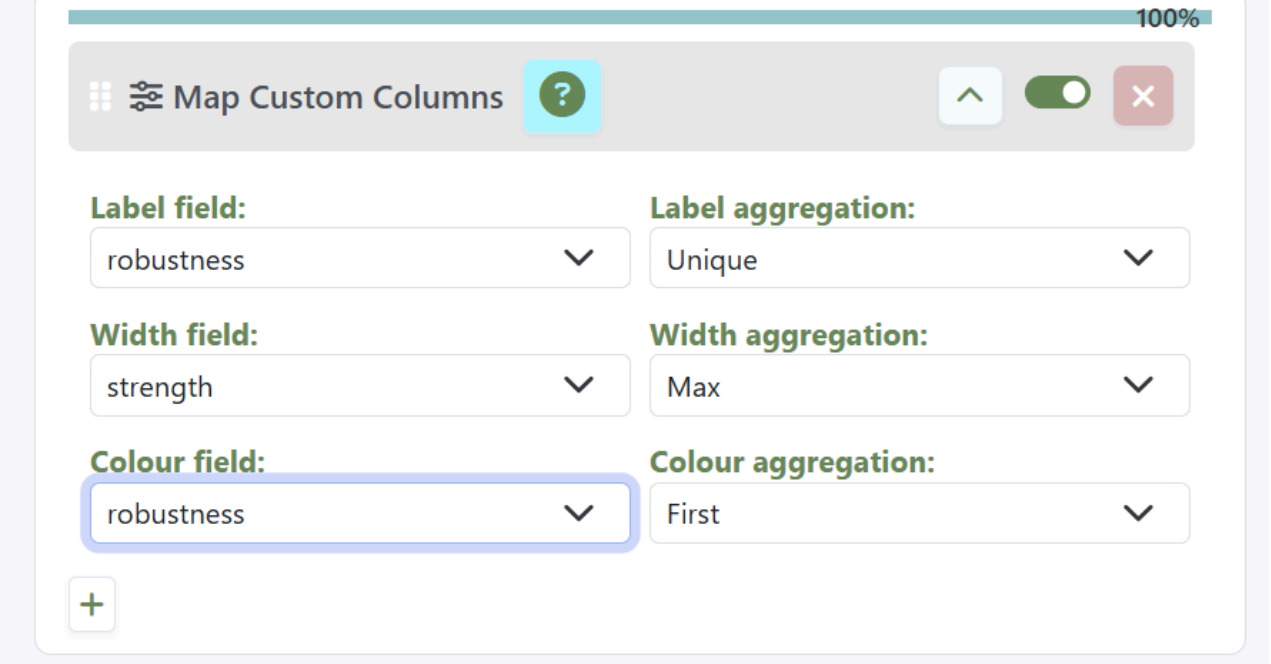

The basic idea is:

1. Use the **Map Custom Columns** filter to choose a link custom column.
2. Tell the filter whether that column should feed **Custom label**, **Custom width**, or **Custom colour**.
3. Choose how values should be aggregated when several links are bundled into one visible edge.
4. In **Map Formatting**, choose **Custom label**, and/or **Custom width**, and/or **Custom colour**. These should be selected automatically.

This matters because the map often shows one visible edge which actually represents several underlying links. So the app needs a rule for combining their values.

Typical label aggregation options are:

- **Unique**: show distinct values only
- **Tally**: show counts by value
- **All**: list all values
- **Average**: for numeric columns
- **Sum**: for numeric columns

Typical width aggregation options are numeric summaries such as:

- **Average**
- **Sum**
- **Max**

Typical colour aggregation options are:

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- **Mode**: most common value
- **First**: first value encountered

Simple examples

Example 1: confidence

Create a custom column called `confidence` and fill it with values such as `1`, `2`, `3`.

You can then:

- sort the links table by confidence
- break the table down by confidence
- use average or max confidence to control map edge width

Example 2: mechanism

Create a custom column called `mechanism` and fill it with values such as `cost`, `motivation`, `trust`, `access`.

You can then:

- group the links table by mechanism
- filter to one mechanism
- show edge labels on the map using unique values or tallies

Example 3: policy area

Create a custom column called `policy_area` and fill it with values such as `health`, `education`, `agriculture`.

You can then:

- compare bundles in the links table by policy area
- use map labels to show which areas are contributing to each connection

A practical tip

Keep the field names simple and stable.

Good examples:

- `confidence`
- `mechanism`
- `policy_area`

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- `time_horizon`

Less good examples:

- `misc`
- `other2`
- `new field`

If you choose a clear field name early, the rest of the coding and analysis is much easier later.

In short

Custom link columns are for structured coding that goes beyond sentiment and tags.

They help when you want to:

- create project-specific coding fields
- analyse links more systematically in the table
- drive map labels, widths, or colours from your own coding

That makes them especially useful once your project moves from simple coding into comparison and analysis.

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Recoding labels temporarily

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Recoding labels temporarily

Sometimes you want to improve your factor labels (cause/effect text) without changing the original data. You might want to:

- **Experiment safely** — try different prompts or AI settings without overwriting what you coded
- **Iterate** — run factor relabelling several times, refining the prompt each time, until you're happy
- **Compare** — switch between original and improved labels to see the difference
- **Review before committing** — only merge into the main cause/effect fields when you're satisfied

The app supports this with two features that work together: **Temporary Cause/Effect Fields** (a filter) and **Target suffix** (in AI Answers → Factors).

How it works

1. **Create temporary columns.** When you run factor relabelling, you can choose a "Target suffix" (e.g. `_temp` or `_version1`). Instead of overwriting `cause` and `effect`, the AI writes to `cause_temp`/`effect_temp` (or `cause_version1`/`effect_version1`). Your original labels stay untouched.

2. **Show them on the map.** Add the **Temporary Cause/Effect Fields** filter in the Filter Links tab. Point it at those same columns (e.g. cause_temp, effect_temp). The map will display the recoded labels instead of the originals.

3. **Iterate.** With the filter active, you can run factor relabelling again. The AI will work on the *current* temp labels (what you see on the map), not the originals. So you can refine prompts, fix odd results, and run again — all without touching the underlying data.

4. **When you're happy**, you can

    1. leave one or more sets of temporary columns as a separate view for analysis. You can switch between different sets and the permanent labels with the Temporary filter.
    2. or rewrite the permanent cause/effect labels with these temporary labels if you want to make the changes permanent. The easiest way to do that is to apply just the Temporary

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filter and then Save As Currently Filtered.

Summary

- **Why:** Experiment, iterate, and compare label improvements without changing your original coding.
- **How:** Use a Target suffix when running factor relabelling, then add the Temporary Cause/Effect Fields filter to display those labels on the map. You can then run factor relabelling again to refine the temp labels further.

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